

The shoguns of Japan

Up until the late 12th century, power in Japan rested squarely with the emperor, who controlled political life. From 1192 until 1868, however, Japan was in effect ruled by a series of shoguns (military dictators), who dominated the government of Japan and reduced the power of the emperor.

Shoguns had existed for centuries as military commanders in the emperor's service, but they slowly gained more and more political power.

Following a civil war, Minamoto Yoritomo set up a military government in Kamakura, independent of the imperial court in Kyoto. He seized power over his rival lords and founded the Kamakura Shogunate in 1192. Minamoto established a feudal system. The emperor, shogun, and *daimyo* (landowning nobles) formed the higher levels of this

system, followed by the samurai. Peasants, craftworkers, merchants, and servants were at the bottom.

Clan wars were common during the Kamakura and later shogunates until the Battle of Sekigahara in 1600, when Tokugawa Ieyasu united the country. He founded the Tokugawa Shogunate in 1603, which ruled Japan until 1867 when the 15th Tokugawa shogun—Yoshinobu—was exiled, and power returned to the emperor.

MINAMOTO YORITOMO

In 1180, an ambitious young noble named Minamoto Yoritomo (1147–1199), started a war against the rival Taira clan, which dominated the imperial court. After defeating his rival, Yoritomo became the first shogun to have complete political

control, meaning that he effectively controlled Japan until his death.



▲ FEUDAL JAPAN

Under the feudal system, the emperor granted land to the daimyo. Samurai were responsible for protecting the daimyo, the lands, and the people who worked in the region. The samurai grew in influence and became an elite class in themselves.



MAJOR SHOGUNATES

1185–1333

Minamoto Yoritomo becomes the first all-powerful shogun and establishes the Kamakura Shogunate. It lasts until 1333 when Emperor Go-Daigo restores imperial rule after victory in the Genkō War.

1338–1573

A former Kamakura general called Ashikaga Takauji—who helped Emperor Go-Daigo win the Genkō War—establishes the Ashikaga Shogunate. It collapses in 1467, after which Japan enters a long period of civil war.

1603–1868

Thirty years after the final fall of the Ashikaga Shogunate, Tokugawa Ieyasu establishes the Tokugawa Shogunate, which presides over a peaceful era that lasts for more than 250 years.

TOKUGAWA
IEYASU

